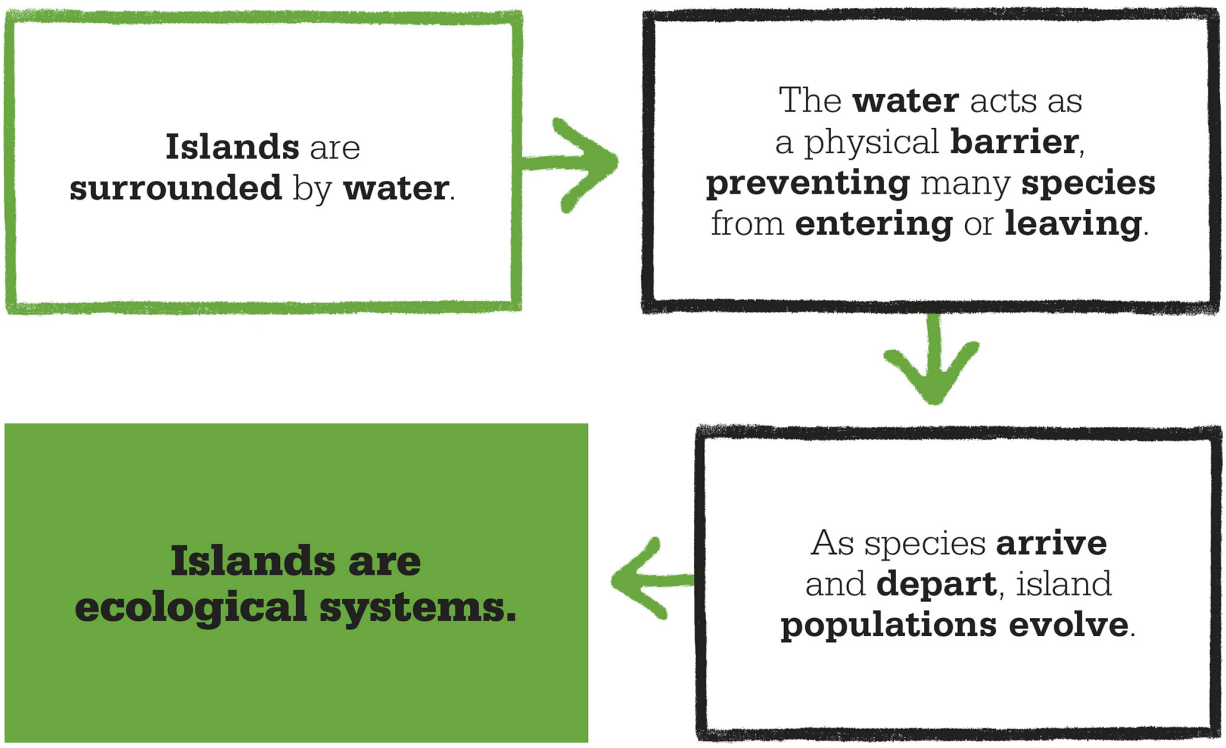


Read accessible description

“Unless we preserve the rest of life, as a sacred duty, we will be endangering ourselves by destroying the home in which we evolved.”

Edward O. Wilson

Monitoring mangroves

In 1969, Wilson and his student Daniel Simberloff conducted a field experiment that tested the theory on six small mangrove islands in the Florida Keys in the US. They recorded the species living there, then fumigated the mangroves to remove all the arthropods, such as insects, spiders, and crustaceans. In each of the next two years, they counted returning species to observe their recolonization. The Florida Keys experiment showed that distance did indeed play a key role: the farther an island was from the mainland, the fewer invertebrates returned to recolonize the area.